darkness. It was Papaji, Maa and Dada smiling at me. For a moment, all other sounds ceased to exist.

‘Chest number 04 . . . 04,’ somebody from behind poked me and I opened my eyes at once. It was my chest number that had just been announced. I walked to Sqn Ldr Yadav’s left at once, and his eyes followed me.

‘That is all,’ he announced.

But we still didn’t know which of the two groups was the lucky one. One of us had to ask him. He replied, ‘I will tell you after dinner; if I say anything now, most of you won’t eat.’

‘As if most of us can savour the meal happily now!’ Hema, who also stood in the same group alongside me, said almost inaudibly.

An early dinner was served. Dinner tables turned into strategic sites for discussions among representatives from both groups, all hell-bent on deciphering the mystery of this unannounced half-result. I wasn’t hungry any more. Or maybe I was, but I didn’t feel like eating a thing! On the television in one corner of the dining hall, a news channel showed Sushmita Sen being crowned Miss Universe 1994. For as long as I sat there, I kept stirring the daal with my spoon, staring at her happy expressions.

We assembled on the same veranda in the two groups after dinner. Sqn Ldr Yadav arrived, dressed in mufti*. ‘For the ones who didn’t clear the test, arrangements for a night’s stay are in place. You can leave tomorrow after breakfast. For those who already have reservations for tonight, a station bus will drop you to the railway station or the bus stop,’ he announced. It was then that I realized that my father had not let me make reservations for the same day, afraid that he would jinx my chances with his presumption.

‘Congratulations to the 105 candidates to my left,’ Sqn Ldr Yadav turned to us and smiled. I let out a sigh of relief; I couldn’t wait to share the news with Papaji. Some girls of our group let out a loud ‘Yes!’. Some hugged each other. I shook hands with Hema and smiled. We had cleared the first obstacle.